> Now your leaders are no longer Cuban leaders inspired by Cuban ideals. They are puppets and agents of an international conspiracy which has turned Cuba against your friends and neighbors in the Americas – and turned it into the first Latin American country to become a target for nuclear war, the first Latin American country to have these weapons on its soil.[64]

Fidel Castro believed he understood the implications of this statement. On Tuesday, 23 October, he appeared on Cuban television and condemned, 'undoubtedly the most reckless adventure, and the most dangerous to world peace since the last world war.'[65] As the week progressed, Cuba prepared for an invasion. The Cuban army, with over 30,000 troops, some 300,000 reservists, and 75,000 militia, prepared to defend their country and its revolutionary government. By 25 October 420,000 troops and militia were ready.[66]

In his one-and-a-half-hour-long soliloquy on Cuban television, Fidel told the Cuban people:

> If there is a direct attack, we will repel it … The people should know the following: we have the means with which to repel a direct attack. This is clear as clear can be … So they threaten us with being the target of nuclear attacks? They don't scare us … We are not intimidated.[67]

He added: 'We have the consolation of knowing that in a thermonuclear war, the aggressors, those who unleash a thermonuclear war, will be exterminated.' True that. What form the aggression might take, and who might take it, was now at the heart of the crisis.